

are helping healthcare providers improve resource utilisation across hospital networks, says Himani Agrawal, Chief Operating Officer of Microsoft India and South Asia. “At Apollo Hospitals, unified data platforms provide real-time visibility across the network, enabling more efficient use of clinician time and infrastructure. Digital tools are streamlining functions such as reporting and claims, lowering operational overheads.”

Apollo’s real-time environmental dashboard captures sustainability data across 40 facilities representing 90% of the group’s total energy consumption.

AFFORDABILITY PARADOX

Behind all these sustainability efforts sits a practical concern—can hospitals reduce their environmental footprint without making healthcare more expensive? India’s healthcare system is already under pressure to deliver affordable care at scale, and hospital groups argue sustainability measures work only when tied to cost savings and resource efficiency.

“Each sustainability initiative is assessed against its expected break-even period, operational impact, and savings potential,” says Debgupta. “Our approach is to integrate sustainability into efficient healthcare delivery, ensuring that environmental responsibility and healthcare delivery progress together.”

Apollo has approached this through financing models tied to savings. Under the JoulePAYS model with Smart Joules, Apollo pays for energy-efficiency upgrades from the savings they generate, without upfront capital investment. Dr Reddy says reductions in energy and water consumption are helping sustainability investments gradually fund themselves over time.



New hospital projects are beginning to incorporate sustainability measures from the planning stage itself

PHOTO BY HARDIK CHHABRA

“The savings are reinvested rather than extracted as margin, making sustainability programmes increasingly self-funding over time.”

At Fortis, sustainability investments are being assessed through savings and resource-efficiency metrics linked to hospital performance. The company says lower energy intensity and wastewater recycling measures are also reducing utility-related costs across facilities.

At Amrita Hospital, sustainability investments are a part of future hospital planning rather than an optional expense. “Hospital leadership is not about whether we can afford sustainability investments, but whether future healthcare systems can afford to ignore them,” says Swami Nijamritananda Puri.

COMPETITIVE RECKONING

Across large hospital groups, sustainability is increasingly being treated as a priority rather than a compliance exercise. SEBI’s mandatory Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reporting framework is bringing structured

accountability to the sector, while NABH accreditation frameworks are beginning to incorporate sustainability standards. International healthcare partners, banks and investors are also scrutinising sustainability disclosures and energy-efficiency metrics more closely.

“Hospitals that invest early in sustainable infrastructure and efficient operations are likely to be better prepared as reporting standards and procurement expectations evolve,” says Dr Reddy. “Talent attraction and retention is increasingly linked to employer ESG credentials, particularly among younger clinical and management professionals. Hospitals that have not invested in sustainable infrastructure will face accreditation and reputational risks.” Debgupta says hospitals integrating sustainability into hospital design, resource management and everyday operations are likely to be better prepared as reporting standards tighten and operating costs rise. **BT**

@richajourno